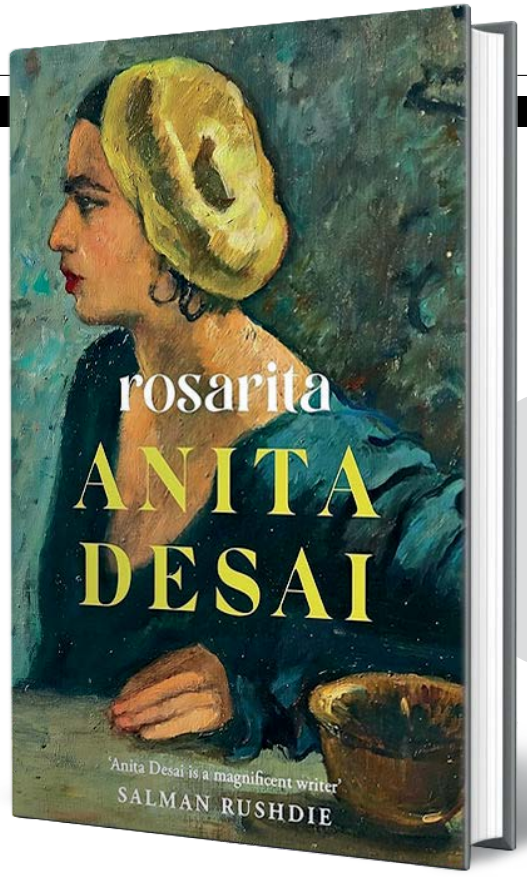


ROSARITA
by Anita Desai
PICADOR INDIA
₹499; 112 pages

Anita Desai, after 13 years of silence, has given you, her reader, a rare gift. A new novel, *rosarita*; a new form, a novel-fragment; a new protagonist, you. If anyone (uncharitably) wondered what Desai might have to offer at 89, these 94 pages of an exquisite hardcover edition hold glimpses of magic. On its jacket, embossed on a gorgeous self-portrait by Amrita Sher-Gil—the Hungarian-Indian painter with an enigmatic, thrilling life-story—is the title *rosarita* in lowercase lettering, with the author's name below it in larger font and bold capitals. Does the sylph-like *rosarita* of this intriguing tale exist, or is she a fantasy, an image of who you could grow up to be, or the one who grew you up: your mother in some secret other life that you never knew of? Does Vicky—the Stranger, morphing into the Trickster—who leads you astray in the course of this telling, exist either?

And you, named Bonita, in Spanish 'pretty' or 'charming', an endearment—have travelled to San Miguel, a small town in Mexico, to learn its language, imbibe its culture, and to run away from a family lineage marked by women's unfreedom, first your grandmother's and then your mother's, the latter's shaped (as far as you know) by 'her unwilling martyrdom' all her life as the meek wife of a successful executive. When you begin to take in the beauty of the verdant Mexican Jardín, the Stranger, an exuberant woman dressed in a flamboyant tiered skirt bears down on you, exhorting that her long-lost, beloved friend Rosarita must be your mother: an 'Oriental bird', just like

Burmese Days

BOOKS

Paul Theroux's new novel is a fictionalised account of George Orwell's time in Burma

After a slew of biographies on George Orwell seeking either to add to his laurels as a genius of grandee standing or (more often) unseat him from sharing the literary firmament with the great English essayist Dr Johnson, comes Paul Theroux's fictionalised account of the awkward young probationer's Burma days. Theroux reconstructs Orwell's embarrassing and disastrous attempt to become a pukka sahib in the "spruce and abusive" Indian Imperial Police in Burma, recapturing brilliantly the visually loud colours, pungent odours, dowry deaths, gang rapes and brutal investigations of rural colonial Burma.

Theroux's familiarity with the landscape as a travel writer is matched by prose so masterful it helps explain the close friendship he later had with Vidia Naipaul. As an American, Theroux mercilessly exposes the British backside to eviscerate the "breathtaking hypocrisy" of the Raj whose "purpose in Burma is to steal". As the "iron heel" convinced "it's the gallows that keeps the Empire safe", Orwell refers to his posting as "a glottal stop ghetto of the Scots", for whom a *dhobi* was someone a policeman was expected to kick.

The silver lining to the apartheid, as the 19-year-old Orwell discovers, lay in the innocence of the doll-like domestic maid-servants in whom he finds "unassertive sensuality". As a sensitive writer of erotica, Theroux suffuses the wonder of physical union with a real sense of ennoblement. As a nature lover he much prefers the company of his ducks, chickens and jungly dog to the "horses, billiards and booze" of the racist upcountry Gymkhana clubs whose members tediously "rubbish one another". Constantly twitted for being a tall, lanky, TB-coughing Old Etonian born in Motihari, Bihar, where his father was a

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